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Jon-Erik Kellso

Jon-Erik Kellso is one of the young instrumentalists keeping the mainstream jazz tradition alive. He was born in Dearborn, Michigan in 1964 and was first inspired by the swing records from his parents' collection. His main influences were not from current trumpet players of his day, but from early pioneers including Bix Beiderbecke, Cootie Williams and Louis Armstrong. He played alongside Wild Bill Davison at 17 and was featured in the Montreux-Detroit Jazz Festival and J.C. Heard Orchestra. Jon has performed with Jim Dapogny's Chicago Jazz Band and Vince Giordano's Night Hawks. He currently has two recordings as a leader on Arbors Records and is increasingly in demand at jazz parties and festivals here and abroad.

Jon was interviewed on September 12, 1997 in Chautauqua, New York by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe. We're filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm pleased to have Jon-Erik Kellso, trumpeter and jazz musician with us today. So let's be honest, what's a nice young man like you doing playing jazz music?

JK: Oh, well, I got interested when I was really young. My parents were both into the Swing Era music, you know they grew up during that time and they had a lot of good old records around the house, so when I was about ten years old I got interested in playing the trumpet, and then after I decided to play trumpet I found out that my father was a trumpet player and had played in some swing bands during the World War II days. And I found some of his old records around, and got interested in it.

MR: Did you pick the trumpet then without him kind of pushing you into it?

JK: Exactly. I didn't even know that he had played trumpet. So I had a built-in first trumpet teacher there. He hadn't played in years but it was kind of amazing — he was able to pick up his old horn, which he still had, and play pretty well, considering how many years it had been since he had touched it. He kind of sounded a little bit like Harry James. So that was my first trumpet idol.

MR: Not a bad guy to sound like.

JK: Yeah. That was his big idol, and that was my first trumpet idol because those were the records that he had.

MR: Well it's perhaps fortunate he didn't try to push you into it, because as kids, you might have rebelled or something. And it's a nice coincidence you picked it on your own.

JK: Yeah, right. It worked out quite well.

MR: Did he talk about what those experiences were like with you? Playing with the big bands?

JK: Yes. He did. He never really got too far with it, I mean he played just, really, when he was kind of a teenager is when he did most of his playing. And he picked it up and started

playing some gigs around Detroit, which is, I'm from near Detroit, and he played with some German bands and some swing combos and big bands, and he talked about it but he said he'd never really had the chops to really make it as a professional. He just was close but no cigar. But he always loved the music. After World War II he gave up playing just to go into other professions — real estate and different things like that.

MR: Well you had a pretty good — I read a little bit about your school experience. You got in a youth orchestra, something like that?

JK: Yeah, I started pretty quick. I mean early on I really took to playing the trumpet right away. I loved it and I just was one of those kids that my parents had to tell me to stop practicing, instead of trying to force me to practice. And so I progressed pretty rapidly. I practiced a lot and I played in — like when I was in elementary school I would sneak over and play with the junior high band, or they actually did ask me to come over to play with them to help out. And when I was in junior high I'd go and play with the high school band. When I was in high school I was playing with a college band.

MR: You were a ringer.

JK: Yeah, kind of. And I had good teachers who knew that that was a good thing for me, to push me as far as testing my limits and putting me in more challenging territory. And I guess it was seventh grade when a friend of mind, Mike Karoub, who is a cello player and bass player, his father was the junior high band director, where I grew up, and his father had gotten him into this group called the International Youth Symphony, which was basically, I was about the youngest guy in it. It was like junior high through college age, people mostly in the Detroit and Windsor areas. And so I started playing in seventh grade in this group, the International Youth Symphony, which was a good youth symphony, very good. And the conductor of the Windsor Symphony, Matti Holli was the conductor for that, and that was quite a challenge, because I hadn't played any orchestral music yet at all, seventh grade you know. And all of a sudden they're talking about transposing, reading A trumpet parts and C trumpet parts, and E flat trumpet parts, and I had never even heard of that yet. So I basically had to learn a lot real quick. And I did well. I always thrived on challenges like that.

MR: I didn't know that that was still required from trumpets — that they'd do that kind of thing.

JK: Yeah. Orchestral, it's standard. Actually the standard trumpet that they use in orchestras is a C trumpet, which is pitched differently than the standard band and jazz band trumpet which is in B flat. So yeah, almost everything was transposing. So it was a good experience.

MR: How did you get into the improvising end of things?

JK: Well I got interested in that pretty early, because like I said I started playing when I was ten and right around the same time I was getting interested in my parents' old records. And you know I asked my Dad about what's going on — what is this? You know I wanted to know more about what was happening, and he'd explain to me when things were written out when things were just guys "taking a ride" as he liked to call it you know. And so I got interested in that and my friend Mike Karoub and I, like I said, we were pals and getting interested in the music at the same time. He was always like one step ahead of me, like because his father was a band director. His father would say, "Hey, you should listen to this record." And then he'd call me up and say, "I've got this record, I think you might like it, it's a guy named Louis Armstrong. It's a little bit older than the stuff you've been listening to, but I think you'd like that." And so we'd get together and we'd listen to these records, and our parents would sort of give us a little steering in the right direction as far as telling us what was going on. And it was fascinating you know.

MR: Can you recall what Louis Armstrong you first heard? Which part of his career?

JK: "Hot Fives," yeah.

MR: Wow, that's a good place to start.

JK: Yeah, exactly. And I have to admit, when I first heard it I kind of didn't know what to make of it because really the only stuff I was familiar with at that point, that being fifth grade you know, was Benny Goodman and Harry James and Count Basie, which I love that stuff. And to hear this at first I hadn't heard anything that old at all of anything. And so the surface noise it was kind of a bad LP copy of it, it was a little bit of work to listen to but I knew it was hitting me hard. I mean I knew that this music was very powerful and great and that he was a great player of course. But it took me a while to really start getting into listening to music from that early on because I was sort of just, it was a little bit harder to listen to for me at that time because of the surface noise and all that.

MR: Yeah. It's hard to get past that kind of limited technology that they were using at the time, but it still sounds funny to hear you say that being in fifth grade I was only familiar with Benny Goodman, you know?

JK: I know it kind of probably sounds funny. Not too many fifth graders these days or even when I was in fifth grade, were really interested in that. We were considered pretty weird by our classmates for being interested in it.

MR: This was, let's see, '69 or '70?

JK: No, I was born in '64. So I guess ten years old is '74, '75.

MR: Okay so I'm trying to think what the pop music at the time might have been.

JK: Oh, like Elton John and—

MR: That influenced you.

JK: Oh that influenced me?

MR: I mean did you get into pop music also?

JK: I mean to an extent, yeah. I mean I wasn't a total jazz nerd, but yeah, I mean I liked some of the Motown stuff because my sister was a bit older than me and had a lot of Motown records around the house, and some oldies rock we had around the house, you know, again, stuff that was before my time but that was some of the things I was interested in as far as pop music.

MR: What about, did you happen to get into groups like Chicago or BS&T that had horn sections?

JK: Yeah, I did like those, and I've always enjoyed those kind of groups too. Fun music. They always had good horn players.

MR: But you were still a jazzer from an early age.

JK: Yeah. I mean that was the thing I was most interested in, but I've always been pretty open minded and listened to a lot of different things, from classical to some pop to whatever.

MR: What about college experience? Did you continue your love of jazz through college?

JK: Yeah. Well like I said, when I was in high school I was playing and getting some summer credits in this program called the Henry Ford Community College Jazz Program, which was directed by a guy names Jack Pearson who was a great teacher and a good influence. And we used to play at the Montreux-Detroit Jazz Festival every summer with that group. And I got to meet a lot of great players there and had some good teachers. And so that's sort of my beginning of my college jazz training there. And then I went into Wayne State University in Detroit after I graduated from Allen Park High School. I started off being a Jazz Studies major. Matt Michaels was a great piano player teacher there who was directing the band. That was a good experience too. I got to go Europe with that band, and met a lot more good players. And I went to school on and off for about six years at Wayne State. I played in the band and again played at the Montreux Jazz Festival and did other types of concerts with that group. It was good, I enjoyed that.

MR: What was happening with your personal tastes as far as the kinds of jazz you were listening to?

JK: Good question. I've been through a lot of phases, I guess you could say. My first listening experiences were Swing Era, then I started sort of going backwards from there and learning about and listening to Bix Beiderbecke and Louis Armstrong, and also then getting into the Eddie Condon group with Bobby Hackett and Wild Bill Davison. And I kind of, I sort of jumped a little bit and then my dad had one Miles Davis record and I listened to that and I thought wow, this is just a completely different way to play the trumpet, but I liked that too. So then I started buying all kinds of Miles Davis records, and from that I learned about Charlie Parker, and one thing would lead to another. You'd

buy one record, looking for one particular guy, and then somebody else on that record opens your eyes and you say now I've got to get this guy's records. So I went through, in high school I started to go through a period where I was buying a lot of bebop records. I liked that too. And I started to play a little bit of the groups that were kind of trying to play that style. And of course the college jazz programs generally aren't really geared towards the older styles of music. They're generally bebop and beyond, you know. But I was interested in that and I was very open minded and I wanted to know as much about every kind of jazz as I could really. And so I was playing in groups that were playing even like Brecker Brothers stuff in college, and you know, fusion, and I went through these different periods where I would really try to give everything a shot and learn what I could from it. And it's funny, now, after going through all these different phases I find myself sort of back to where I started, you know, with playing mostly music from the Swing Era, give or take a little bit from traditional jazz, Dixieland, whatever you want to call it — swing music, small group swing.

MR: Is this market for — I don't know what to call it — mainstream I guess — I mean what you're going to playing tonight, is that a decent word for it?

JK: Yeah, it's as good as any. I'm not —

MR: Classic.

JK: Yeah, there's a lot of different names for it. I don't really mind any of the titles for it.

MR: It's basically — correct me if I'm wrong — based on tunes from the '30s and '40s?

JK: Yeah, even a lot from the '20s too. A lot of people think of some songs as being from the '40s when they were really written in the '20s or even the teens sometimes.

MR: And how did you go about — was there a method to trying to memorize and learn these tunes? Because I'm always interested in how all these people fly in from different parts of the country, and this promoter, hopefully puts them together in workable ensembles, and then you get up there and the designated leader says, okay, here's the tunes, let's go.

JK: Yeah. Sometimes you talk it over beforehand, sometimes you don't. Sometimes you're just on the stand and you'd better to know the song they call or else you're going to be embarrassed or you're going to be scuffling a little bit. And for the trumpet player it's a little bit more pressure than the other guys in the band, because the trumpet player is generally expected to play the melody, at least so they can recognize it. And so I mean if you're the clarinet player in the front line, playing sort of ensemble, free-wheeling kind of playing, if you've got good ears you can hear the chord changes even if you've never heard the song before, you can generally, you've got the first chorus to listen to the rhythm section and the trumpet player and sort of fill in. And you can get away with something. I mean not to put down any of the other members of the band, but it is a little bit of an extra pressure. You have to know the songs you know. And so I kind of learned

under interesting circumstances, because starting out as young as I did, my first big job — major, steady gig — was playing at a place called Greenfield Village in Dearborn, Michigan, which is where the Henry Ford Museum is. And my friend Mike Karoub, who I mentioned before, he always had a lot of chutzpah you know. And aside from being a great player, he was very ambitious, that may be a better word for it. But he decided, we had started playing around at PTA meetings, playing Dixieland arrangements that his father would help us dig up, and swing band stuff, big band stuff. We actually had a big band when I was in fifth grade and he was in sixth grade, playing big band classics. And we decided it was easier to have like a six piece group because there were six people who could improvise. You know the rest were sort of like scuffling along you know.

MR: No one's mother would let them come to rehearsal.

JK: It was hard. A big band is always a hard thing to schedule and keep together. It's a lot of logistics involved. Six people is a little less complicated and we could also, we just were gravitating toward that kind of music anyway. So he decided he'd call up Greenfield Village, because it was kind of like this sort of trip back into time sort of place. And I said, "Well what you need there is a Dixieland band, you know, to play outside and down by the river there." They had a gazebo, and they said, "That's an interesting idea, so why don't you come in and audition." So we went in and auditioned and played like the six songs that we knew, or whatever it was at that point. And it went well and they hired us and they said, "Great, you're going to be playing six days a week, five hours a day, for the summer."

MR: And you were how old?

JK: I was, I'm trying to remember. I was either going into seventh grade — no, going into eighth grade I think, yeah. Somewhere between seventh and eighth grade. And so all of a sudden, here we are playing five hours a day, six days a week, and we got pretty tired of those — well it might have been a dozen songs or something that we knew by heart and then we had some arrangements. So we just started finding ways, whatever we could, to buy arrangements of old tunes that we liked, and also just learn things from records and lead sheets and sheet music, and we just sort of helped each other through it and learned a lot of songs in a hurry, mostly just to keep ourselves from going crazy and playing the same songs all the time.

MR: Did you get any press from that? I would imagine that, you know, this young group of kids in there.

JK: Yeah. We also started to get to know more of the musicians around town because even then we'd have to sub out some dates, because whenever so-and-so would have a football game or a baseball game or whatever, a family commitment or something like that. So we started to get to know some of the better, older players around town, because there wasn't

anything in our contract that it had to be kids playing. So I mean they liked that, I think it was one of the selling points. But anyway, so we got to know a lot of the players around Detroit and there was quite a few, and there still are quite a few good players of all different styles there. It's always been a good music city.

MR: That's a great story. You're kind of used to hearing that kind of story from the guys that grew up in the '20s and '30s. It just seems to fit those times more.

JK: Sometimes I think we were born in the wrong era.

MR: Funny you should say that, I've felt that way myself, yeah. Today, in the market, being a jazz musician, is it a — I don't want to get too personal — is it a decent way to make a living? Is it hard?

JK: Yeah, I'd have to say it is not an easy way to make a living. But again, on the other hand, I'm really happy and fortunate and pleased to be doing what I've always wanted to do. And I make a living. I do okay. Let's say this: it's not an easy way to get rich. I didn't get into music to become rich. But I do okay. I've always managed to be able to be a full time musician and pay my bills and you know, I do okay. But there's only a select few really that do, that are able to do that, compared to the musicians that just decide well okay I'll just do this on the side and have a "day gig" as they say.

MR: Do you augment these kind of gigs with anything like pit bands or playing theater shows, that kind of thing?

JK: Not so much theater and pit bands. I do live in New York so you'd think maybe I was doing Broadway. But that's kind of a very specific kind of playing that I'm not as interested in and not really as cut out for that, although I read and everything, that's not the problem, it's just that I don't think I would enjoy it mostly. But I have always done different kinds of gigs and I'll do private parties, which could mean weddings or anniversary parties, or things like that, dances, or oh, any number of things, all kinds of little industrial events, sometimes they'll hire a band to play. And you know all different kinds of things like that. And I have played like shows behind singers in groups. Back when I lived in Detroit I used to play in bands. The Motown groups would come through town and use local horn sections. They'd have their rhythm sections that they'd travel with and they'd hire local horn players, and that was fun. I got to play with, you know, the Temptations and the Four Tops, and Martha Reeves, and the OJ's, and groups like that. And that was fun. They were always very professional, nice guys and I think they really appreciated the Detroit horn sections because most of us had grown up with that music and we knew how it was supposed to go. They didn't have to go through and rehearse too long with us, you know.

MR: Looks good on your resume, too, huh?

JK: Yeah. I played with the Temptations — you know. Except the people at a party like this, an event like this, probably wouldn't be as excited about that as the younger folks. They'd say what is this, rock & roll? Yeah I've always done kind of a variety of gigs. That's one of the things I like about being a musician is that I'm not always playing with the same people and at the same kind of place. I kind of like the challenge of doing a variety of kinds of music.

MR: Have you been able to kind of play alongside some of your influences or heroes?

JK: Yeah. That's a good one. Yeah, I was very fortunate. Aside from meeting the local heroes around Detroit and playing with some of them, which were probably mostly names you might not know but it was a thrill, every year I'd get to play with better and better musicians. One of the first ones I got to play with was a guy named Tom Saunders in Detroit, who is a very great cornet player and I used to go and hear him when I wasn't even really old enough to be in the bars that he was playing in, but we'd go and hear him, and he introduced me to Wild Bill Davison. He was sort of a protege friend of Wild Bill's. And he used to bring in Wild Bill to this club that he played in in the Detroit area whenever he could. And sometimes he'd have him in town for a week or two weeks or something like that, or just one concert. And so he put on a concert called "Four Generations of Jazz Cornet" and I was the young generation, there was a guy from Boston named Paul Monnet, who was maybe in his thirties at the time, and then Tom was in his forties, maybe fifties at the time, and then Wild Bill, I don't remember how old he was at the time, you know, pushing 80 I suppose, I'm not sure. But that was when I was about 17 or 18 I think when we did that. So that was a thrill. I got to meet Wild Bill who was one of my favorites at the time and still is. And I got to play with Doc Cheatham a couple of times, and that was exciting. We had a group in Detroit called "The New McKinney's Cottonpickers" which was based on the original McKinney's Cottonpickers, which was a Detroit group, way, way, way back, which had included Doc Cheatham and Benny Carter and all kinds of great players. And so we put on this concert, this was one of the greatest days of my life. It was at Detroit's Orchestra Hall, which some say the acoustics are better than Carnegie Hall. And I was playing in two different groups that were the two featured groups on this concert. So it was "The New McKinney's Cottonpickers" featuring Doc Cheatham, which was a thrill. And then I was in this group, J.C. Heard's Big Band, and of course J.C. Heard was one of the great jazz drummers and he settled in Detroit and had a very good big band that I played with. And he and Dizzy Gillespie shared the same birthday, same year, and they were friends from way, way back, and so the idea was to have the two of them celebrate their birthday together in this concert. And this was the other half of this concert. I got to meet and play with two of my all-time idols. So the sad part of it was J.C. Heard passed away the night before the

concert, which was a shock. He was going to be 72 I believe. We had played with him two nights before, and he was in great shape and full of energy and playing great, no signs of any health problems. He just all of a sudden had a heart attack and that was it. And I'll never forget how well Dizzy Gillespie handled this. We did the concert with one of J.C.'s proteges, a guy named Billy Cairo, a drummer in Detroit, and Dizzy managed to pay tribute to J.C., his old friend, really nicely, but also make it a happy thing and remember the good times and tell some funny stories and just made people feel good, you know, instead of it being like this whole downer. So that was a real exciting thing for me.

MR: He certainly had that knack of making people feel good.

JK: Yeah. And also the other thing that was exciting about that was we were playing mostly Dizzy's, maybe entirely Dizzy's arrangements, his old big band arrangements. And we had an extensive rehearsal with him. And having him show us how these compositions were meant to be played was really enlightening and fun. He was serious about it. He did joke around a lot, but he was serious about the music. He was especially hard on the drummer I'll say, who was a good drummer, but there was a lot of stuff that you don't write into the chart that you just have to know, and he could be very specific. He knew a lot about drumming and also, he was going to be filling some big shoes, stepping in for J.C. Heard. So he wanted to make sure that this guy did a good job, and he did.

MR: Seems like I read somewhere that he even taught Art Blakey to play drums or something.

JK: I wouldn't doubt that he at least had some things to share when him, to help him. Because he was one of the first guys into the Afro-Cuban influence on jazz, and combining those things together. And I think he taught a lot of people stuff about that you know.

MR: Well I wanted to play something here, and see if you recognize it.

[audio interlude]

MR: That is you, right?

JK: That's me.

MR: Okay.

JK: That's a good question, because there's two cornet players on that album. It could be a little confusing. That's the first released album that I'm on.

MR: Well, you're probably familiar with what they said about you, but I wanted to get your opinion on it, regarding this particular tune, it says "Kellso tips his horn just a bit in Bix Beiderbecke's direction. There are also occasional nods towards Billy Butterfield's lyrical constructions and Wild Bill Davison's ruminating low notes." Did you know you were doing all that?

JK: Well it wasn't entirely conscious, but I'd have to say I'm honored that he said those nice things. I think those are certainly some of the people that influenced me a lot and

especially when playing this kind of music in that kind of setting. So he was on the ball. Who was that? Was that Floyd Levin?

MR: I'm glad to hear you say that because sometimes you — Floyd Levin, yeah.

JK: Yeah, he's a good writer, good guy.

MR: Sometimes you wonder, when you read things that the critics or record reviewers write, if the musicians really agree with it you know.

JK: Yeah, sometimes they're right on and they see things as musicians do or close to it, or they describe things in a very good way, which is a hard thing to do, describing music with words has always been a challenging thing. So I have to give these guys some credit and give them a little leeway. But there's times when they come up with stuff and it's like, is he listening to the same thing that I'm listening to? Or they read a lot into things sometimes. But he's one of the good ones, and I'm honored that he'd say those things about me.

MR: Well I like the fact that on your little breaks that you had in there, you didn't choose to just fill them with a million notes, like sometimes younger players do. That's what Cal Collins told me this morning, he said it.

JK: Well it's true. Yeah, I like to play a more, kind of a lean style, and just try and make the notes count a little bit more, you know, the ones that I play. I've never been much of the player who tries to play a zillion notes. And I think especially in the older styles or whatever you want to call it — swing or traditional jazz — it's less appropriate anyway. It just doesn't sound right when the trumpet player is playing a zillion notes, especially when you're playing in the ensembles and playing the lead melody. I learned early on from some of the older guys beating it into me, saying, you know, if you're going to be playing during ensembles, if you play the trumpet, you play the trumpet part and don't play all the fills, you know there's two or three other horn players around who have their roles to do, and so if you can just play a nice, simple, tasteful melody that leaves holes, leaves space, that's one of the best early lessons I learned from the guys around Detroit and I try to remember that. That's what makes it work. Everybody has to do their part and leave room for the other guys to do their part. So it's something I try to think about.

MR: Yeah. You have to think about the context that you're in. This particular album was more arranged than some of the — well here we go with words again — classic or whatever. Were these Rick Fay's arrangements?

JK: Rick Fay is the leader on this. It's called "This is Where I Came In" right? Arbors Records? Dan Barrett was on there and I think that was Dan Barrett's arrangement, which was taken largely from one of Bix Beiderbecke's versions of that song. And he did a lot of arrangements on that album. I think Marty Grosz did do some arrangements on that

album as well. A lot of those guys are here — Marty Grosz, Dan Barrett, Hal Smith is here.

MR: Tell me, were you nervous?

JK: A little bit, yeah, yeah. In a way it was really my second recording session. The other one came out later so I say that this was my first CD because it came out first. Yeah, I mean I was playing with all these top guys. I mean everybody on that album was tops. And I was relatively new to playing with guys of that caliber. After moving to New York I started meeting guys like Dan Barrett, who introduced me to some of these other guys. It was a thrill. It was exciting. I was more uptight then about like wanting everything to be perfect, and worrying about it more than I do now, after having done several recordings. You realize if you worry too much about that you can drive yourself crazy. I'd play the tapes back and I'd get down on myself for everything that wasn't exactly the way I intended it to be. Now I listen back to it and you know, I forgot what I intended to play, so you know if it came out okay, fine.

MR: That's jazz I guess.

JK: Right. Not that it's not as important to me that it comes out right, but I just used to really drive myself crazy about it.

MR: You've got two, at least two, under your own name now?

JK: Right.

MR: One almost brand new? And on your first album you had Milt Hinton?

JK: Yeah, I sure did.

MR: That must have been a good experience.

JK: Oh, boy, yeah. Well he was the highlight of that session for me, which was full of great musical moments and playing with great guys. Again, they were all top-notch guys. Mat Domber of Arbors Records was great because he asked me to do this CD after having done a few as a sideman for him. And of course that was a great thrill and honor. But also he really left it in my hands to pick the guys and the tunes and the studio and the engineer, and so I really got to do it my own way and write some original tunes and arrangements. And as I was considering who to hire for this record, I started thinking of guys and of course you want to play with guys that you feel comfortable with and guys that are the best guys available and guys that you think will sound good together, and I was thinking about a bass player and I thought well why not just start at the top? You know and the worst thing he can say is no, right? So I went who's the best bass player I've played with, and I had done maybe a half dozen gigs with Milt Hinton. I thought well you can't really beat him. And so I called him up and he was really nice about it. You know because I think like the pay was probably less than he's used to because he'd been used to playing on bigger labels and stuff like that. So I think he made an exception

because he's always liked to help out and encourage younger players who he felt were on the right track or trying to keep the music going and all of that. So he did it and I was thrilled. And he was a great help and a great inspiration in the studio. There was times when I would start to count off a tune and I'd think wait a second, I should ask Milt to count this tune off. Because he was on like the original recording of it and has played it with all the best bands in history. And if anybody knows what tempo this should be it's going to be him. And so that was a nice thing to be able to sort of fall back on him and use his experience and try to just take advantage of him in the best way possible as far as just using his inspiration. And he had such a good feeling of warmth about him in the studio. He kept everybody at ease. You'd think playing with him would have you terrified or something, but he has a way of putting you at ease and just making things feel comfortable. And he'd tell some little stories when he'd have a little break, and some of that Mat captured on video, too. That should be in some archive too, I guess it's in Mat's archives. But that's pretty neat. I've got a copy of that. And the other thing that's funny, you know he was the oldest guy in the band by far. I don't recall, he might have been 80 at the time, or 79 or something like that. But he also seemed to have the most energy. It's amazing. You know he was in great shape and playing at the top of his form. And there was times when I was very concerned about making sure he was comfortable and that we weren't overworking him. And so there was times when I'd just kind of look around and act like I was talking with the whole band when really I was thinking of him. I'd say, "Well maybe it's time we should take a break now," you know I didn't want anybody to feel overworked. But he knew when we should keep going, like say the band was starting to get a groove going, and a nice energy, and there's times like that where people like him know that, let's knock another song out right away because he knew that we all had this groove going and we could do that. And he was always right. Because usually when he'd say that we'd knock some song off in one take because everybody just had this momentum going. So he was great that way.

MR: That's terrific. He's a real treasure.

JK: Oh, I'll say. Yeah. I was very thrilled to have him there.

MR: How long did you have to do these records? Did they give you a day or two?

JK: Yeah. Two sessions. That was called "Chapter One," we did that in two, I guess five hour sessions, maybe six hours on one of them; and then the second one is called "Chapter Two" — surprise, surprise — the plot thickens. And that was about the same, I think maybe two six hour sessions, two afternoons.

MR: Well good for you.

JK: Yeah, I was very thrilled with the results of those because it's always kind of a calculated risk when you're — well what I did is I took a lot of friends and favorite musicians of

mine who didn't necessarily all know each other or even have played together, and I just could hear in my head that these guys would sound good together, and it worked in both cases. It doesn't always work you know. You might have an all-star band and they don't always click. But in these cases, I felt good about it.

MR: Was it an added concern that the tunes of your own that you brought to the session would be accepted, like, "Oh yeah, nice tune."

JK: Oh yeah, I mean that's another thing. In both cases on both of those albums, I brought in these songs and I had never heard them performed. We had no rehearsals as a band, just the guys are flying in front different places, or the guys just didn't know each other or were too busy to get together to rehearse. So we get into the studio and a lot of times I'd save those for the end, because you know if we have time we'll try this out to see if it sounds right. If it just feels right, we'll go ahead with them. So that's what I did. I had two originals on the first album and one on the second. And I was pleasantly surprised that they sounded like I thought they would sound and even better really because the guys were so good they knew how to just instantly take this lead sheet or arrangement and make it into music instead of just reading a bunch of notes. They read into it and added their own experience to it.

MR: I've heard that for some record people that that is a little bit of a risk, to put a lot of original stuff, because sometimes people pick that up and they buy it because they see tunes they know.

JK: Yeah, I mean I even do that sometimes. There's times when I look at an album and I see all these original songs that I've never heard of, and sometimes I might opt for the one that has some songs that I know or songs that I want to know, a lot of times I'll buy CDs because I want to learn a song sometimes. I want to look for a classic version of it. So I can kind of understand that, but at the same time it's nice to hear originals and keep that kind of spirit going in jazz too.

MR: Someone's got to write the tunes that will be the standards in 20, 30 years from now.

JK: Exactly, yeah. So there's got to be a balance there somehow. I just put a couple in there, so I don't think people mind too much. If they don't like those tracks then can just skip to the next.

MR: You can program the CD. What's your take on the racial atmosphere in today's jazz scene?

Is there one that is prevalent, or not?

JK: Well yeah, it's kind of a strange subject because I think there's a lot of sort of cliques and I don't think it's always necessarily that the guys don't want to play together as far as blacks and whites, but I think for some reason it ends up being sort of little like a scene of guys or a clique of guys who are together and then there's this other clique playing

together. And I'm surprised sometimes at how often I'll play in bands that are all white. And the guys are all open minded people who are not prejudiced, and I think it's a funny thing. I don't really understand it. I feel very fortunate that I grew up in a family that was really not prejudiced and put those feelings into me as a kid, and brought me up to feel that way. I think it's kind of weird. Of course there are prejudiced people out there, musicians and not musicians, and it's always seemed funny to me how few black people you see at these jazz parties, on the stage and off the stage. Because especially when it's more toward Dixieland or traditional jazz or whatever you want to call it. I think it just sort of became not the cool thing to do among black people. I don't really understand it exactly.

MR: There seems to be very few black musicians playing this well — especially Dixieland. Probably down in New Orleans and so forth, but when you go to some of the festivals that have a lot of the Dixieland bands, it's turned more into, well it's changed. They have the costumes and all that.

JK: Yeah I don't know how to answer that question and I think there's been racial issues regarding Wynton Marsalis and his groups of guys, and I think — I don't know if he's been misquoted or not but there was times when people got the impression that he was maybe prejudiced, but I don't think he necessarily is. I think since these things have become hot topics, I think he's made a point of having more white people in his bands and stuff like that, and this is just my take on it, I don't know. It's kind of an icky subject.

MR: It is. It doesn't have a good answer, and it could be an answer we don't want to hear too.

JK: Yeah, exactly. And I think maybe the term "Dixieland" probably turned a lot of black people off. The idea of Dixie and the south and the bad connotations of way down home in Dixie and all that, I don't know, maybe that's part of it.

MR: Could be. I didn't think of that. Did you notice, as long as we're talking about that, your listening habits, could you tell a difference between New Orleans Classic Jazz and Chicago? Was there a difference in your eyes, in your ears?

JK: That's a tricky one because these labels sometimes are misused and misconstrued, but labels in general can cause confusion as much as they can clarify. And a lot of the music that they call "Chicago Jazz" is really New Orleans guys taking their music to Chicago and meeting guys from Chicago and from other places, and sort of a change some, it certainly changed some, but as Jelly Roll Morton's music that he recorded in Chicago "Chicago Jazz" or "New Orleans Jazz?" I don't know. What do you want to call it. And then there are recordings that were actually made in New Orleans and they had a certain flavor to them, and you know, it certainly was more of an emphasis on ensemble playing and less solos, and after Louis Armstrong and Sidney Bechet started making names for themselves as the brilliant soloists they were, I think in Chicago it became more of an

emphasis on the solos, and there was still an ensemble going on and an emphasis on ensemble but there'd be a lot more solos. I'd say if there is really one difference, that would be the major difference. But it's a little blurred because a lot of those guys were patterning themselves after New Orleans musicians and New Orleans bands, but they'd sort of come up with their own way of doing it.

MR: It's tough. It seems like every time you make a statement about jazz you have to say but then there was this. It's a music that has moved through so many things so fast. I don't know. And you seem to have listened to almost all of them.

JK: Well I try to do my homework. It's all interesting to me, so I have a zillion 78s and records and CDs at home.

MR: Well if we were to do an interview every ten years, do you have any career goals in mind that ten years from now we'd be talking about the fact that you have done what?

JK: Well I'm pretty happy with the way things are going. I've already gotten to do two albums of my own and I've played with some of my heroes. It's not that I've done it all yet, I don't mean that, but I'd like to continue to do more work as a leader perhaps and do more albums as a leader as well as playing with more of my heroes and just making great music, the greatest music I can, and trying to put music out there that people want to hear and maybe come up more and more with some of my own ideas and ways of playing it that increasingly have my own voice basically. And I wouldn't mind making a little bit of money along the way too. I know people don't like to think about musicians thinking about that but I wouldn't mind having a little bit more money in the bank.

MR: Don't you just do it for the love of it?

JK: Well mostly, yeah. Or else I would have maybe been a stockbroker or something, if I was really concerned about making money.

MR: You had an awful lot of good advice and guidance. Would you have anything to say to a young trumpet player who might not have the kind of foundation that you had but was still aspiring to a career in jazz? Nothing like ending with an easy question.

JK: No, that's a good one. It's something I've put some thought into. I've had some students and occasionally have private students so it's something I've thought about. I think for a young aspiring jazz trumpet player of course you've got to listen to some of the great records and do your homework as I said, you know, go back and listen to Louis Armstrong and listen to the greats throughout history. And put it together in your own way. And then also, I think one of the most important things that a lot of the young musicians don't really catch on to is they just need to get out and play as much as possible with groups. Because there's guys who go through high school and college, and most of their playing is done with their Jamey Aebersold play along records, which can be a useful tool to practice with, but they're not used to playing with other musicians.

And they go out and play a gig and they might as well be playing along with the record. They're not interacting, which is one of the big joys and important things in jazz that some people overlook or forget about, that it's really supposed to be about this magical kind of interaction where you're listening to him and you pick up a little thing that he did and he bounces off of you, and this guy is playing harmony, and you can't really learn to do that otherwise than from just doing it. You just have to get out and play with guys and play with the best guys you can, and go out and listen to live music and pay attention to what's going on on stage, and notice all this stuff. I think those are some of the most important things. It helps to practice too. Learn the foundations of your instrument. I feel very fortunate I had a good background as far as good private teachers and a little bit of a classical background so I was studying that at the same time I was studying jazz really, listening to the records and learning solos off of records, trying to get inside the heads of these greats and learn a solo and analyze, how do these notes that he played relate to the melody and relate to the chord structure, and just trying to figure out what was he thinking? You have to just try and sort of get into their heads and then not necessarily end up being a copy of them but you can learn from even the deceased great jazz people, and get a private lesson from them in a way by doing that.

MR: When you're improvising, are you thinking about the chords that are going by?

JK: That's a good question. I think it sort of depends on how well I know the song sometimes. When I'm improvising on a song that I'm familiar with, I'm not really thinking about the chords because they're just sort of, I know them, I understand how the song is put together and how the chords fit together, and I'm thinking more about, really I guess the best answer is when you're really improvising you're not really thinking in a way. It's more of like a Zen kind of thing really. It's more like you just sort of, you've done your preparation, you know the song, and you're just sort of in the moment, you know what I mean? You're listening to what's going on around you, and you're thinking maybe about the melody or maybe you're thinking about what the previous solo, what he ended with, you might just start with that idea and elaborate on that, or you're basically just constructing a new melody. And I try to think more melodically than chordally in my solos, and just think of making a melodic line. But there's times when I don't know a song very well, which might very well happen here, where you're really listening very hard to the chords and the bass, to hear how the harmony ties together. So you're really listening to that and just trying to lock into that and then trying to jump to that other stage, like you know the song, without forgetting to listen to what's going on around you. You might not know what's coming ahead, and you have to really just react quickly. You have to have really quick ears and really quick reflexes sometimes, and just respond that way.

MR: A very good description. And you hope that the bass player and the piano player know the tunes.

JK: That could be a real problem. I've had those gigs where there's the blind leading the blind and it can really be a disaster. But hopefully you have a leader who's going to be smart enough to know what's safe and what would make sense as far as songs that will come off. It doesn't always happen. Of course we always take risks in jazz and that's part of it. There's a lot of times where at least somebody in the group doesn't know the song as well as he'd like to, but like I said, you hopefully develop your ears enough so that you have these fast reflexes and you can respond to that.

MR: I think there's a certain amount of trying to make the audience think you know the song, even though maybe —

JK: Yeah, I know the song, sure.

MR: You never know. Sometimes the comments you get, people say, "Oh that was really, really great" and you're feeling like whoa, I didn't really know what I was doing there.

JK: You're wiping the sweat off like I guess I pulled that off, I don't know. Yeah sometimes you feel like you might have been horrible because of the feelings going on inside you like you were just barely holding on, where if you're a professional a lot of times you can play it off. And it happens.

MR: Well I've really enjoyed talking to you and I wish you the best in your career, and we'll do this again a few years from now maybe and see what's going on.

JK: I've enjoyed talking to you to, you had great questions.

MR: Well on behalf of Hamilton College, I'd like to thank Jon-Erik Kellso for being with us, and I hope you have a great gig and no one calls too many tunes that you don't know.

JK: Thank you.

MR: Okay. Good luck to you.